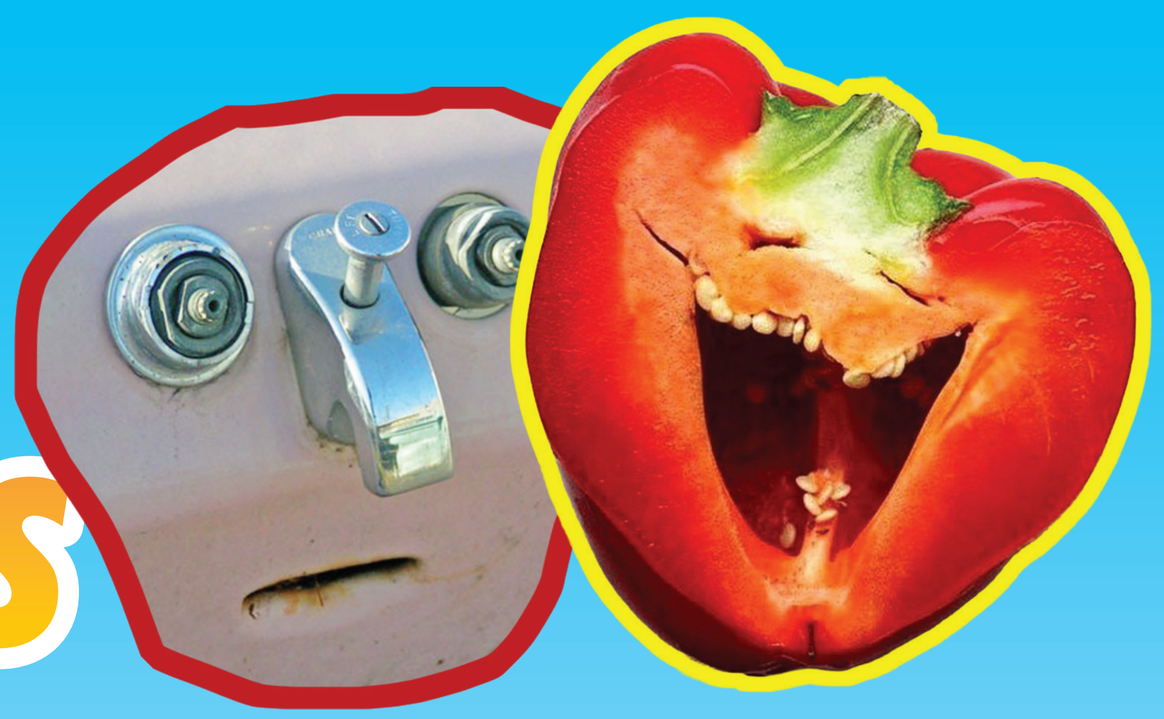
Andrea Cheng

THINGS THAT LOOK LIKE OTHER THINGS



How does partial visual information change the way an image is categorized?

Project Description

This project explores how partial visual information changes the way an image is categorized. I created an archive of humorous and visually ambiguous images, then trained a Teachable Machine model to classify them into four categories. Through an interactive website, users gradually erase a surface to reveal an image and observe how the machine's reading shifts as more visual evidence becomes available.

What the Model Revealed

During training, the boundaries between the four categories began to dissolve. A single image could suggest several visual illusions at once, while the model responded to whichever shape, texture, or face-like feature appeared most dominant. Its precise confidence scores made these temporary and overlapping interpretations appear certain. These moments of confusion revealed classification as a shifting act of attention rather than a fixed description of an image.



FACES IN THINGS

Everyday objects or still-life elements are accidentally arranged to form the appearance of a face.

SHAPE IMITATION

One thing copies or resembles the recognizable form of another.

MATERIAL ILLUSION

Something appears to be made from a material that it is not.

FORCED PERSPECTIVE

Camera angle, distance, or scale changes how objects appear to relate in space.



Prototype Design Proposal

The interactive prototype gradually reveals an image while the model continuously reclassifies what it can see. As visual evidence accumulates, category labels move, compete, and change in confidence. The experience makes classification visible as an unstable process shaped by partial information rather than a fixed answer.

